

Neo-Confucianism

The neo-Confucianism that became dominant in Korea under the Choson dynasty had evolved in China during the 11th and 12th centuries as a means to revive Confucianism, which had declined in favor of Taoism and Buddhism under the Tang and early Song. A more rationalist and secular form of Confucianism, the new philosophy rejected superstitious and mystical elements that had influenced Confucianism during

and after the Han dynasty. Writers such as Confucian scholar Zhu Xi stressed the importance of morality, respect for social harmony, and education as means of understanding the Supreme Ultimate (*tai qi*), the underlying principle of the universe. In practice, however, neo-Confucian virtues such as loyalty, determination, and the belief that a supreme monarch should rule the state to parallel the Supreme Ultimate that governed the universe, tended to favor a hierarchical, bureaucratic

state staffed by scholars who jealously maintained the status quo.



Hyanggaeryo were Confucian schools, built throughout provincial Korea and used for both ceremonial and educational purposes.

to new heights, founding in 1420 the Chiphyŏn-jŏn (Hall of Worthies), an elite group of 20 scholars tasked with research that would promote the better running of the kingdom.

Encouragement of wider literacy was an important neo-Confucian ideal, and Taejo had already ordered the foundation of government-sponsored schools. At the time, however, Korean was written in Chinese characters, which were not well adapted to express the sounds of the language. Sejong himself is said to have developed the simplified script, the Han'gŭl, whose principles were explained in *Proper Sounds for the Education of the People*, a book published in 1445. Having only 28 characters—later reduced to 24—the script was far easier than Chinese was

to learn, but its introduction faced bitter resistance from traditionalist nobles. They feared it might open civil service examinations to people from other social classes, which would risk diluting their power. As a result Han'gŭl faded from use, relegated as the “vulgar letters” of the lower orders, until its rediscovery in the 19th century, since when it has thrived as a vehicle for Korean nationalism.

The reforms of Taejo and Sejong, however, broadly survived, creating a class of yangban—elite government officials dedicated to the perpetuation of the state. The yangban also acted as a break on any tendency to autocracy among the Yi monarchs, which helped the resulting dynasty endure for more than five centuries. ■

